

Evaluation of the ENGAGE! Women's Participation & Active Citizenship Project



ENGAGE!
Women's Empowerment &
Active Citizenship



In partnership with
Canada

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Report Information

Report Title: Evaluation of the ENGAGE! Women's Empowerment and Active Citizenship Project

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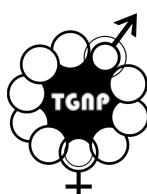
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List of Acronyms

ABCD	Asset-Based, Community-Led Development
CCDB	Christian Commission for Development in Bangladesh
CLE	Centre Haïtien du Leadership et de l'Excellence
GAC	Global Affairs Canada
KII	Key Informant Interview
MEL	Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning
MSC	Most Significant Change
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
OECD-DAC	Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development – Development Assistance Committee
PMF	Performance Measurement Framework
TGNP	Tanzania Gender Networking Programme
ToT	Training of Trainers
WISE	Organization for Women in Self Employment
SEWA	Self Employed Women's Association
SGD	Small Group Discussion

1. Introduction

1.1 Project Overview

The ENGAGE! Women's Empowerment and Active Citizenship project was a 6.5-year initiative (2019–2026) aimed at advancing gender equality and reducing poverty by strengthening women's capacity to participate in the social and economic life of their communities. Funded by Global Affairs Canada (GAC), the project was co-designed by Coady Institute in partnership with five implementing organizations across five countries:

- Self Employed Women's Association (SEWA) in India;
- Organization for Women in Self Employment (WISE) in Ethiopia;
- Tanzania Gender Networking Programme (TGNP) in Tanzania;
- Christian Commission for Development (CCDB) in Bangladesh; and
- Centre Haïtien du Leadership et de l'Excellence (CLE) in Haiti.

Together, these partners anchored implementation in diverse community, organizational, political, and cultural contexts, while working toward a shared set of outcomes.

The project was grounded in an asset-based, community-led development (ABCD) approach, which emphasizes leveraging existing community assets – particularly women's leadership capacities – to challenge inequitable power relations and support improvements in gender equality that are internally driven, resourced, sustained, accountable, and rights-based. Across countries, partners addressed a range of context-specific priorities affecting women's lives, including climate adaptation, young women's leadership and entrepreneurship, the future of work in the informal sector, urban poverty through women's economic development, and women's participation in community governance through gender-responsive budgeting.

In addition to supporting tangible community-level outcomes, the project strengthened organizational capacity and leadership among partner organizations and their networks. A strong knowledge and learning agenda further enabled partners to expand their outreach and influence, supporting broader contributions to women's leadership and gender equality at local, national, and regional levels.

Table 1: Project Objectives

1000 Ultimate Outcome: Enhanced empowerment and active citizenship of women and girls in the five target countries		
1100 Intermediate Outcome: <i>Effective leaders:</i> Strengthened leadership of women and men for gender-equitable, community-driven change processes in their communities in the five target countries.	1200 Intermediate Outcome: <i>Enhanced Organizational Leadership:</i> Enhanced performance of civil society organizations (particularly women’s rights organizations) in supporting women’s leadership in the five target countries.	1300 Intermediate Outcome: <i>Outreach and Influence:</i> Improved and increased use of gender-equitable, community-driven policies and practices within and beyond the five target countries.

Project activities comprised a combination of:

- Support for community-based training of women leaders and related community initiatives that advanced gender equality;
- Capacity-building support for partner organizations and their local, national, and regional networks; and
- Learning-focused activities (including action research, case study documentation, and curriculum development) that built on community initiatives and supported the sharing of lessons learned through various dissemination and training opportunities.

As project lead and convener, Coady Institute was responsible for overall project management and accountability to GAC. It also coordinated cross-partner processes related to governance, baseline development, monitoring, and evaluation, and provided ongoing technical and capacity-building support to partners and their networks. This role aimed to foster coherence across countries while maintaining flexibility for partners to adapt implementation to their specific institutional and community contexts.

While Coady held formal “lead agency” designation for contractual purposes, the project was guided by a non-hierarchical approach to partnership. Through ongoing dialogue and collaboration, all partners contributed leadership across different components of the project.

2. Evaluation Scope & Objectives

2.1 Evaluation Purpose

This final evaluation is designed to support accountability and learning. It assesses the extent to which the ENGAGE project achieved its intended outcomes, as well as the broader contributions and changes across the five countries of focus.

Conducted in collaboration with Coady and project partners, this evaluation aims to:

- Assess the extent to which the project achieved its intended results, using the Performance Measurement Framework (PMF) as the primary reference point and, where feasible, comparing progress against the pre-implementation baseline;
- Identify and document key lessons and implementation challenges that emerged over the course of the project; and
- Develop actionable recommendations to inform the design and delivery of future initiatives aimed at advancing gender equality and supporting gender-equitable change.

2.2 Evaluation Audience and Use

Evaluation findings are intended to support evidence-based decision-making and learning at multiple levels. Results inform reporting to GAC on project performance and outcomes, contribute to reflection on future programming and partnership opportunities, and strengthen approaches to partnership and gender-equitable programming among Coady and project partners.

Key intended users of this evaluation include:

- GAC staff;
- Coady leadership and project team;
- Implementing partner organizations (CCDB, CLE, SEWA, TGNP, and WISE); and
- Community stakeholders, organizations, and networks involved in project implementation.

Together, these intended uses aim to ensure that the evaluation produces credible, actionable evidence that supports reflection, learning, and its practical application among key stakeholders.

3. Evaluation Framework

This evaluation was structured around the OECD-DAC evaluation criteria to ensure rigour and alignment with international best practices. This framework supported assessment of the project's performance across six key dimensions – relevance, effectiveness, efficiency, coherence, impact, and sustainability – and the generation of evidence-based insights to inform accountability and learning.

Table 2. Evaluation Framework and Criteria

OECD-DAC Criteria	Definition
Relevance	The extent to which the intervention objectives and design respond to beneficiaries, global, country, and partner/institution needs, policies, and priorities, and continue to do so if circumstances change.
Effectiveness	The extent to which the intervention achieved, or is expected to achieve, its objectives, and its results, including any differential results across groups.
Efficiency	The extent to which the intervention delivers, or is likely to deliver, results in an economic and timely way.
Coherence	The extent to which the intervention is compatible with other interventions in a country, sector, or institution, and how well it complements, harmonizes with, and adds value to existing efforts while avoiding duplication.
Impact	The extent to which the intervention has generated, or is expected to generate, significant positive or negative, intended or unintended, higher-level effects.
Sustainability	The extent to which the net benefits of the intervention continue, or are likely to continue.

3.1 Evaluation Questions

This evaluation was guided by a set of key questions aligned with the OECD-DAC criteria, designed to assess the project's performance and contributions across its areas of intervention. These questions were refined and validated through consultation with the evaluation team, Coady, and project partners.

The questions provided a structured framework to examine what was achieved, how and why results emerged, and the factors that enabled or constrained progress. They also supported analysis of cross-cutting issues, including gender equality, partnership dynamics, and contextual influences across the five countries. Together, they ensured a focused and

systematic inquiry, generating evidence to support accountability and forward-looking learning.

Table 3. Evaluation Questions

OECD-DAC Criteria	Evaluation Questions
Relevance	To what extent were the project's objectives and design aligned with the needs and priorities of implementing organizations and participants, specifically women, and how relevant are the project's approaches and results in the current context?
Effectiveness	To what extent has the project achieved its intended results, and what factors have enhanced or constrained these results?
Efficiency	To what extent were project activities implemented in a timely and cost-efficient manner, and what lessons can inform improvements in efficiency for similar initiatives?
Coherence	To what extent did the project complement other gender equality initiatives in the countries of focus, and avoid duplication or overlap?
Impact	To what extent has the project contributed to women's and girls' empowerment and active citizenship in the five target countries, and what lessons can be drawn to improve impact in similar initiatives?
Sustainability	To what extent are project results likely to be sustained by participants, partners, and communities, and what factors support or constrain their sustainability?

4. Evaluation Approach and Methodology

4.1 Approach

This evaluation applied a feminist approach grounded in collaboration, reflexivity, and responsiveness, co-created with Coady and project partners to complement ENGAGE's ABCD approach. This included:

- Co-designing the evaluation process with Coady and country partners through individual and group consultations, regular check-in meetings, and ongoing communication;
- Conducting virtual and in-person data collection across all implementation countries to ensure regionally balanced and contextually grounded analysis;
- Using qualitative, open-ended, and storytelling-based prompts in interviews and small group discussions to center participants' experiences;
- Engaging country-based consultants to strengthen linguistic and contextual understanding during data collection;
- Incorporating partner feedback and collective sensemaking processes to inform both data collection and analysis; and
- Upholding ethical, safeguarding, and data protection standards while supporting inclusive and participatory data collection.

This approach contributed to a responsive and contextually grounded evaluation process, strengthening the quality, credibility, and overall relevance of the analysis.

4.2 Methodology

This evaluation adopted a mixed-methods design to generate robust, evidence-based findings. It combined qualitative and quantitative data collection methods to enable triangulation across sources, capturing both measurable results and diverse stakeholder perspectives. The methodology assessed project performance against the PMF and OECD-DAC criteria, while also identifying patterns, outcomes, and variations across country contexts. This approach supported a comprehensive analysis of results and generated actionable insights to inform future programming and decision-making.

4.3 Methods

A range of complementary data collection methods were used to ensure a comprehensive and balanced evidence base. These included:

- Review of project documentation;
- Key informant interviews (KIIs) with stakeholders across project management, implementation, and ecosystem levels; and

- Small group discussions (SGDs) with project participants across all implementation countries.

KIIs and SGDs engaged stakeholders across three groups: (i) project management and implementation actors (Coady and partner staff); (ii) donor representatives (GAC); and (iii) project participants and local stakeholders, including government, civil society organizations and networks engaged in project activities. KIIs primarily engaged project management, donor, and ecosystem stakeholders, while SGDs focused on project participants.

Where relevant and available, quantitative data from the PMF were also analyzed to assess progress against expected results. Together, these methods enabled triangulation of findings, capturing both outcome-level changes and the lived experiences of those directly engaged in the project.

Table 4. Data Collection Overview

Data Source	Stakeholder Group	Description	Scope
Document Review	–	Review of key project and partner documentation, including proposals, operational reports, monitoring data, and knowledge and communication products	64 documents
KIIs	Project management and implementation actors	Interviews with Coady and partner organization staff (e.g., leadership, project managers, MEL staff)	20 stakeholders
KIIs	Donor representatives	Interviews with GAC representatives	3 stakeholders
KIIs	Local stakeholders	Interviews with government, civil society organizations, networks, and other actors engaged in or linked to project implementation across partner countries	16 stakeholders
SGDs	Project participants	Group discussions with women engaged in project activities, including leadership training, training-of-trainers (ToT), community-based training, and advocacy activities	138 stakeholders

Table 5. Data Collection By Country and Stakeholder Type

Stakeholder Type	Bangladesh	Canada	Ethiopia	Haiti	India	Tanzania
Project management and implementation actors	3	9	2	3	2	1
Donor representatives	0	3	0	0	0	0
Local stakeholders	3	0	3	4	3	3
Project participants	44	0	23	21	20	30
Sub Total	50 (47 women, 1 man)	12 (10 women, 2 men)	28 (22 women, 6 men)	28 (26 women, 2 men)	25 (23 women, 2 men)	34 (28 women, 6 men)
Total	177 (158 women, 19 men)					

Document Review

The team conducted a targeted review of key internal and external project documents (64 total), including project proposals, operational reports, annual reports, logframes, monitoring data, and knowledge and communications products. This review provided important context on project design, implementation, and outcomes. Documents were shared with the evaluation team during the inception phase, with additional materials incorporated throughout the evaluation based on stakeholder recommendations and targeted searches.

The team systematically recorded and analysed each document, capturing key details, summarising findings, identifying challenges and gaps, linking content to OECD-DAC criteria, and noting follow-up questions to guide primary data collection. This structured approach supported triangulation with primary data and strengthened the overall evidence base.

Key Informant Interviews

Semi-structured interviews were used to collect primary data from a range of stakeholders, including Coady and partner organization staff (e.g., executive directors, project managers, MEL staff), GAC representatives (e.g., program managers), and actors from government, civil society organizations, and networks engaged in or linked to project implementation across partner countries. These interviews provided in-depth insights into project implementation, contextual dynamics, partnership approaches, and outcomes.

A purposive sample of stakeholders was selected to ensure representation across project roles and implementation countries. Interviews were conducted both in-person and remotely, depending on location and availability, with in-person data collection prioritized where feasible to support contextually-grounded engagement.

Small Group Discussions

The team facilitated virtual and in-person SGD's across all implementation countries, grouped by stakeholder and activity type. This included staff participants in Coady courses; participants in ToT and leadership programs; community-based training participants; and participants engaged in local advocacy activities. Discussions explored participants' experiences with ENGAGE activities, as well as perceived changes in knowledge, skills, leadership, agency, confidence, peer networks, and collective action.

Open-ended and storytelling-based prompts were used to encourage inclusive participation and support participant-led reflection and knowledge sharing. Participants were invited to share stories illustrating the most meaningful changes they experienced through their involvement in the project. These narratives provided deeper insight into how and why change occurred and informed the evaluation's understanding of outcomes and sustainability at individual, institutional, and community levels.

4.4 Limitations of the Evaluation Design

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the findings of this evaluation. First, while the evaluation incorporated both virtual and in-person data collection across all implementation countries, the number of in-person SGD with project participants (particularly community-based training participants) was limited by budgetary and logistical constraints. As a result, some perspectives may be underrepresented, particularly among women facing greater barriers to participation or mobility, including women in more remote or rural areas.

Second, the evaluation relied primarily on qualitative and self-reported data to assess changes related to leadership, confidence, agency, and participation. While these methods were well aligned with the project's feminist and participatory approach and enabled deeper exploration of lived experiences, some findings reflect participants' perceptions and experiences rather than independently verifiable long-term outcomes.

Finally, ongoing political instability and insecurity in some implementation contexts created occasional limitations for participation in cross-country evaluation activities. For example, CCDB staff were ultimately unable to travel to Tanzania to participate in an in-person data validation workshop due to visa restrictions. While project partners were given an additional opportunity to review findings at the draft report stage, this limitation potentially reduced opportunities for full in-person cross-partner reflection and exchange during the data analysis stage.

5. Data Analysis

Data analysis followed a structured approach aligned with the evaluation framework and OECD-DAC criteria. This approach ensured consistent analysis across stakeholder groups while allowing space for emergent findings and reflective insights.

5.1 Framework-Based Thematic Analysis

Qualitative data, including KII and SGD transcripts and facilitator notes, were analysed using a thematic coding framework structured around the six evaluation criteria and corresponding indicators outlined in the Evaluation Matrix ([Annex 1](#)). Data excerpts were reviewed and categorized according to:

- Evaluation question
- Corresponding indicator (e.g., organizational capacity strengthening, individual changes in confidence / agency, inefficiencies in project implementation, sustainability risks, etc.)
- Stakeholder type (e.g., community-based training participants, partner organization staff, Coady staff, etc.)

- Implementation country
- Emergent themes (e.g., changes in women's leadership, changes in household dynamics / practices, challenges adopting new knowledge, project design recommendations, etc.)
- Type of evidence, using four categories:
 - Confirming evidence
 - Divergent or disconfirming views
 - Illustrative quotes or stories
 - Suggested adaptations or actions

A collaborative coding process was used, relying on a shared matrix rather than qualitative analysis software, to support transparency and collective interpretation. Evaluation team members extracted and summarized relevant excerpts from transcripts and notes into a common analysis matrix, assigning each entry to the appropriate evaluation criterion and indicator. This approach enabled identification of patterns across implementation countries and stakeholder groups while maintaining consistency in interpretation.

Qualitative data, including stories of change, examples, and quotes, were then synthesized and clustered by types of change, such as shifts in knowledge, skills, leadership, agency, confidence, peer networks, collective action, organizational practices, and community engagement. This supported deeper analysis of how and why change occurred, and helped identify contribution pathways linking project activities to observed outcomes.

Regular team debriefs and synthesis sessions were held throughout data collection and analysis. These sessions were used to share emerging findings, compare interpretations, and identify cross-cutting themes, including differences across contexts and stakeholder groups. This process helped ensure that diverse perspectives – particularly those of structurally excluded groups, such as women participants – remained central to the analysis.

5.2 Data Triangulation and Validation

Evaluation findings were triangulated across data sources and stakeholder perspectives to strengthen credibility and analytical rigour. Areas of convergence and divergence were explicitly identified and examined.

A validation workshop was held with Coady and partner organization staff in Dar es Salaam, Tanzania, in March 2026 to share preliminary findings and support collective sense-making. The session provided an opportunity to test and refine findings, deepen interpretation, surface nuance, and identify gaps or areas requiring further analysis. Further validation was provided through an all-partner collective review of the first draft of the report and a detailed review of the second draft by Coady's MEL Manager. Together, these processes informed the final analysis and strengthened the credibility and contextual grounding of the evaluation.

6. Findings

This section presents the evaluation findings, structured around the OECD-DAC criteria and associated evaluation questions. Findings draw on triangulated evidence from document review, KIIs, and SGDs across all implementation countries. Together, they reflect cross-cutting patterns as well as variations across contexts and stakeholder groups.

6.1 Relevance

To what extent were the project's objectives and design aligned with the needs and priorities of implementing organizations and participants, specifically women, and how relevant are the project's approaches and results in the current context?

Finding: The project's objectives were strongly aligned with implementing organizations' mandates by building on existing priorities through an asset-based and partner-centered design.

Across all interviews with project partners, there is consistent evidence that the project's objectives are closely aligned with implementing organizations' core mandates, particularly in relation to women's leadership, empowerment, and economic inclusion. This alignment was not incidental but reflected a deliberate design choice to build on existing organizational priorities rather than introduce externally defined agendas. As one partner explained, the objectives of the "ENGAGE project [are] highly aligned with our mission [...] promoting women's leadership, awareness about rights, active citizenship," while another noted that "all of the program elements fit... everything was designed based on what we were doing."

This alignment was enabled by the project's non-hierarchical, asset-based approach, which positioned partners as collaborators with recognized expertise and capacities. Rather than introducing new models, the project reinforced and expanded ongoing work, allowing organizations to deepen areas such as leadership development, advocacy, and community engagement. In several cases, the project also enabled partners to extend into adjacent areas, such as entrepreneurship or multi-country collaboration, without disrupting core programming. As a result, the project was not experienced as a parallel initiative but became embedded within organizational strategies – strengthening ownership and supporting the sustainability of outcomes beyond the project period.

"All of the program elements fit... everything was designed based on what we were doing."

– ENGAGE Partner Organization Staff

Finding: Participatory design and decentralized decision-making were central mechanisms through which alignment with partner priorities was achieved and sustained.

Alignment with organizational needs was driven by a participatory design process that extended from initial co-design through ongoing implementation. Several respondents emphasized that partners were actively involved in shaping the project, with one noting that “it was a very participatory process [...] partners were actively involved in the co-designing.”

This participatory foundation was operationalized through decentralized decision-making and governance structures, including a Project Steering Committee that intentionally included representatives from Coady and each partner organization, creating a formal space for shared oversight and decision-making. Joint annual planning processes in which partners defined activities based on their contextual priorities further enabled this approach. As a result, alignment was continuously reinforced rather than fixed at the outset. As one partner explained, “we are the ones who propose what we think will work,” highlighting the level of autonomy embedded in the model. Organizations also retained the flexibility to adapt or decline activities that were not relevant. For example, one organization described opting out of a particular research component because “it just wasn’t really relevant [...] and they understood.”

This level of flexibility and agency is a key mechanism for maintaining alignment in complex programs, particularly where partners operate in diverse and rapidly changing contexts. By enabling organizations to define, adapt, and even reject activities, the project reduced the risk of implementing interventions that were misaligned with local realities. It also strengthened ownership, as partners were not simply delivering pre-designed outputs but actively shaping the direction of the project based on their expertise and contextual knowledge.

However, the data suggests that participation within this model was not evenly distributed across stakeholder groups. While core implementing partners were meaningfully engaged in co-design and planning processes, this level of influence was not extended to community members, including women participants themselves. As a result, alignment with women’s needs was often mediated through partner organizations, rather than directly co-defined with participants. In practice, this meant that while partners brought strong contextual understanding, the project did not systematically establish structured mechanisms for women to shape priorities at the design stage.

This distinction is important, as it highlights different levels of participation. At the organizational level, participation was relatively high, with partners exercising substantive decision-making power. At the community level, however, participation was more concentrated in implementation (e.g., engagement in training, feedback through activities) rather than in agenda-setting or design. This may have limited the project’s ability to capture

more nuanced or emerging priorities among women, particularly those that fall outside organizational programming frameworks or are less visible through formal consultation processes.

The implications of this finding are twofold. First, while the project achieved strong alignment overall, there is potential to deepen this alignment by strengthening direct participation of women in design and adaptation processes – for example, through structured co-creation workshops, iterative feedback loops, or community-led planning mechanisms. Second, the finding highlights a common tension in multi-partner programs between efficiency and inclusivity: relying on partners as intermediaries enables scale and coordination, but can also filter whose voices are reflected in project design. Addressing this tension is critical for moving from alignment “in principle” to alignment that is fully grounded in participants’ lived priorities.

Finding: A flexible and non-standardized design enabled strong contextual alignment across countries, though it required capacity and coordination to operationalize.

The project’s flexible design was a central enabling factor for alignment across diverse country contexts. By allowing partners to adapt indicators, redefine outcomes, and tailor activities, the project avoided imposing uniform solutions in settings with very different socio-economic and political realities. As one partner emphasized, “it’s not about putting everyone in one basket [...] but understanding those differences.” In Haiti, for example, this contextual alignment was reinforced by the materials and methods used in delivery. Community-based training participants described the content as staying very rooted in Haitian reality, noting that the materials felt adapted to their context and that the language used felt familiar and accessible. As one participant put it, “the content felt right at home”.

This flexibility allowed partners to pursue different pathways toward shared objectives: in some contexts, economic empowerment through financial access was prioritized, while in others, leadership development or advocacy were more central. The ability to adjust MEL indicators also enabled partners to capture context-specific forms of participation and change that would not have been reflected in standardized metrics.

However, this flexibility introduced complexity. One Coady staff member described the project’s logframe as “wide enough to drive a truck through,” emphasizing the openness of the design. While this enabled adaptation, it also created ambiguity, particularly in early phases, and required strong coordination and capacity to manage effectively. As one partner stated, “the [project’s] flexibility was both a gift and a challenge in this case.” This finding highlights that flexibility is essential for alignment, but must be accompanied by adequate support and clarity to be fully effective.

Finding: Alignment strengthened over time through iterative learning and increasing clarity in project processes.

Alignment was not static but evolved over the course of implementation. Multiple partners described an initial period of uncertainty, particularly in relation to understanding project structures, MEL systems, and the role of different components such as research and learning. As one staff member reflected in relation to MEL, “There was a real learning curve [...] at the beginning, it was a lot to manage. But over time, we came to understand it – we now eat, breathe and sleep these numbers.”

As familiarity with processes increased and coordination mechanisms strengthened, alignment improved. This was particularly evident in later phases, where partners reported greater clarity in how their activities contributed to broader project objectives. Clearer processes and stronger coordination facilitated this shift, allowing for more effective integration of different components. This finding underscores that alignment in complex, multi-partner programs is iterative. It depends not only on design features but also on sustained learning and increasing clarity over time.

Finding: Donor-driven MEL and reporting requirements created tensions between accountability needs and the project's adaptive and transformative objectives.

While the project's design emphasized flexibility, contextualization, and participatory approaches, these principles were partially constrained by donor-driven MEL and reporting requirements. Across interviews, partners consistently described reporting systems as complex, time-intensive, and heavily oriented toward quantitative indicators. As one staff member noted, reporting was “very number focused [...] limiting our capacity to capture the most meaningful changes experienced by participants,” pointing to a disconnect between how change was experienced on the ground and how it was formally captured.

This misalignment was not simply a technical issue but reflected a deeper tension between the nature of the outcomes the project sought to achieve and the tools used to measure them. Many of the project's most significant changes, such as shifts in women's confidence, agency, peer networks, and collective action, were inherently qualitative, non-linear, and difficult to quantify. For example, participants described increased confidence speaking in public spaces, greater willingness to challenge discriminatory practices within households and communities, and stronger solidarity networks among women leaders. While these changes were often highly meaningful to participants and viewed by partners as important precursors to longer-term structural transformation, they were not always easily captured through standardized quantitative indicators. As a result, some of these dimensions of change were underrepresented in formal reporting, creating a partial picture of project impact.

The project did attempt to address this tension through more adaptive and contextualized MEL approaches. This included the identification of partner-specific progress markers and

the use of change journals at multiple reporting intervals to document more qualitative and emergent forms of change, and opportunities for partner-led action-based research. These mechanisms created additional space for partners to reflect on contextual outcomes and capture stories of transformation that extended beyond standardized indicators. However, despite these adaptations, partners continued to describe the broader reporting architecture as heavily oriented toward quantitative accountability requirements. While some flexibility existed at the country level, the overall MEL structure remained demanding and comparatively rigid, limiting the extent to which partners could systematically integrate emergent and unintended outcomes into formal reporting systems. In some cases, partners attempted to address these gaps informally through storytelling, case studies, or internal documentation, though these efforts were not always fully reflected in donor reporting processes.

The implication is that alignment cannot be fully achieved at the level of design and implementation if it is not also reflected in how success is defined and measured. For future projects that aim to support complex social change processes, MEL systems need to be equally adaptive, participatory, and context-sensitive, incorporating qualitative methods and space for emergent learning. Without this, there is a risk that the very outcomes the project seeks to promote remain insufficiently visible within formal accountability structures.

Finding: Project activities were relevant to and aligned with women's priorities, particularly in relation to livelihoods and economic empowerment.

The evaluation found that the project was consistently well aligned with participants' immediate needs and priorities across contexts. During SGDs, participants described training activities as closely reflecting their priorities, particularly around livelihoods, basic business skills, income generation, facilitation, and practical skill development, with high reported relevance across countries (85–100%, according to PMF data).¹ Motivations for participation also extended beyond immediate needs to include longer-term aspirations such as professional growth, networking, and peer learning.

Training activities were most closely aligned with participants' economic and livelihood priorities. Women consistently described being motivated and engaging in training to strengthen income generation, financial stability, and economic independence. This alignment reflected partner-led needs identification and contextually adapted implementation, enabling activities to respond to locally defined priorities.

Participants also emphasized the practical applicability of training, particularly in financial management and livelihood skills. As one woman explained, “before that I did not really understand [...] tracking money [...] this training gave me tools I still use now.” Another noted, “now if I earn 10 taka, I save 2 taka,” illustrating how training translated into tangible behavioural change. This relevance was reinforced through contextual adaptation: for

¹ ENGAGE! Annual Report (2025).

example, livelihood support in Bangladesh was aligned with climate-related challenges, while in Haiti, financial management and entrepreneurship training responded to local demand.

However, participants also identified persistent structural barriers – particularly limited access to capital, markets, and broader economic opportunities – which constrained their ability to fully apply and scale the skills acquired. Project partners WISE, SEWA, and CLE sought to address these constraints through initiatives focused on access to finance, entrepreneurship support, and livelihood strengthening. In Haiti, for example, CLE established a pilot financing vehicle to provide growth capital to social entrepreneurs, raising approximately USD \$100,000 in low-interest debt financing and distributing more than USD \$25,000 through trust-based loan products to ENGAGE participants over the life of the project. These efforts represented important contributions toward strengthening women's economic resilience and expanding access to resources.

Despite these efforts, participants and partners alike emphasized that broader structural constraints continued to limit the extent to which gains translated into sustained and transformative economic outcomes. This suggests that achieving more durable results in women's economic empowerment requires complementary support, including expanded access to finance, stronger market linkages, and enabling policy and institutional environments.

Finding: Micro-level contextual adaptation in community-based training activities ensured accessibility and relevance for women with diverse capacities.

Alignment with women participants' needs was not only achieved at the level of project design but operationalized through continuous micro-level adaptation in delivery by partner organizations. Across contexts, partners described actively adjusting both the content and format of training to reflect participants' diverse literacy levels, economic realities, and time availability. For example, in contexts where women had limited formal education, partners introduced basic literacy and numeracy components as a prerequisite to engaging with more technical content. In other settings, training was delivered in shorter, staggered, or more flexible formats to accommodate women balancing paid work and/or domestic responsibilities, recognizing that rigid delivery models could exclude those most in need.

Adaptation also extended to pedagogy and facilitation methods. Partner organizations reported translating training materials into local dialects, simplifying language and terminology, and relying on practical, experience-based examples rather than abstract concepts. In some cases, training incorporated real-life scenarios, peer exchange, and demonstration-based learning to ensure comprehension and applicability. These adjustments were not incidental but reflected an ongoing process of responsive facilitation, where trainers observed participants' levels of understanding and engagement and adapted in real time. As a result, women were not only able to attend training but to

meaningfully engage with and apply what they learned, increasing both uptake and perceived relevance.

However, while these micro-level adaptations strengthened alignment in practice, the data indicates that the identification and prioritization of women's needs remained largely mediated through partner organizations rather than directly co-defined with participants. In other words, while partners demonstrated strong contextual knowledge and responsiveness, women themselves were not consistently engaged in structured ways to shape project priorities at the design stage. This distinction is important: adaptation occurred primarily at the level of delivery (how activities were implemented), rather than at the level of agenda-setting (what activities were prioritized).

This approach to mediation has important implications. On one hand, it reflects a pragmatic and often effective model, as partner organizations are deeply embedded in communities and possess strong contextual knowledge and trusted relationships with participants. This positioned partners well to identify emerging challenges and adapt programming in responsive ways. On the other hand, relying primarily on partner-mediated identification of priorities can introduce a filtering effect, where women's priorities are interpreted through organizational lenses, which may not fully capture more nuanced, emerging, or less visible concerns. For example, while economic and livelihood priorities were strongly reflected in programming, more sensitive issues – such as intra-household power dynamics or informal mobility constraints – may be more difficult to surface consistently without structured mechanisms for direct engagement.

The finding therefore points to a two-tiered model of alignment within the community-based training activities: strong alignment in implementation through adaptive delivery, alongside more indirect alignment in design through partner mediation. This model appears to have been effective in supporting accessibility, relevance, and feasibility across diverse contexts. At the same time, the evaluation suggests there may be opportunities to further strengthen women's direct participation in shaping project priorities and feedback processes, including through community-led planning sessions, iterative consultation cycles, or participatory monitoring approaches. Ultimately, this highlights that alignment is not a binary condition but exists along a spectrum. ENGAGE demonstrated a high degree of practical alignment through adaptation and responsiveness, while also pointing toward opportunities to deepen participant voice, influence, and agenda-setting within program design processes.

6.2 Effectiveness

To what extent has the project achieved its intended results, and what factors have enhanced or constrained these results, including the contribution of feminist and gender-transformative practices?

Figure 1: Endline Results from the Performance Measurement Framework

Indicator	Target	Analysis of Progress
Ultimate Outcome 1000: Enhanced empowerment and active citizenship of women and girls in the six target countries		
% of case studies conducted with partners and targeted communities that show the Initiative empowered women and girls' active citizenship in the six target countries	75%	Above target in all countries
Intermediate Outcome 1100: Strengthened leadership of women and men for gender equitable community-driven change processes in their communities in the six target countries		
Change in level and quality of influence of women and girls in community decision-making structures	Moves one step (from low to medium, or from medium to high)	Mixed (on or above target in all countries)
% of F/M Coady and partner graduates who report sharing and applying gender-equitable community- and asset-based approaches in their organization and/or community	50%	Above target
Immediate Outcome 1110: Strengthened knowledge skills, attitudes and motivations of women and men for mobilizing communities to advance gender equality		
% of F/M graduates and community-based participants who report report an increase in their knowledge and skills	80%	Above target
% of F/M participants (disaggregated by other demographic information where pertinent) report that training was relevant	80%	Above target
Immediate Outcome 1120: Increased capacity of women to claim their rights and participate in local decision-making		
Graduates', partner organizations', and community members' perceptions of the changes in attitudes, behaviour of girls/women in targeted communities	Varies by country / partner	Mixed (below, on, or above target across countries)

Indicator	Target	Analysis of Progress
Graduates', partner organizations', and community members' perceptions of the commitment of duty-bearers to uphold women's rights	Varies by country / partner	Mixed (on or above target in all countries)
Intermediate Outcome 1200: Enhanced performance of civil society organizations (most particularly women's rights organizations) in supporting women's leadership in the six target countries		
Indicators to measure progress in various domains of capacity (e.g., women's transformative leadership, gender equitable structures and process, strategic gender relationships and linkages, transformative programming and advocacy).	75%	Mixed (below or above target across countries)
Immediate Outcome 1210: Improved delivery of women-centered ABCD training and support by local partners and their networks		
# of new and revised training programs designed, delivered and improved upon based on Coady methodology	48	Above target
Partner and network staff report increased confidence in delivering women's centered ABCD training and support	Varies by country / partner	Data not available ²
Immediate Outcome 1220: Increased capacity of CSOs (particularly women's rights organizations) to advance community-driven approaches to gender equality		
% of country-level network members who report that joint initiatives are relevant to community-driven approaches to gender equality	75%	Above target
% of country-level network members who report that joint initiatives advance community-driven approaches to gender equality	75%	Above target
Intermediate Outcome 1300: Improved and increased use of gender equitable, community driven policies and practices within and beyond the five target countries		

² Baseline and targets were set qualitatively, but the final indicator was measured as a percentage; therefore, results are not directly comparable.

Indicator	Target	Analysis of Progress
# of meetings granted by relevant policymakers, number of presentations in external events, profile of participants of those events	70	Above target
# of requests for technical assistance and advice on innovative practices, tools, or approaches	50	Above target
Immediate Outcome 1310: Increased knowledge and skills of partners and their networks to develop innovative documentation of and evidence for gender-equitable community-driven initiatives		
% of action research and innovation partners (or women and men practitioners from selected partner organizations who participated in the assessment and documentation of the innovation) who report that ABCD approaches, tools and strategies strengthened support to women's leadership	75%	Above target
Immediate Outcome 1320: Increased awareness of and access to innovative practices on women's leadership for community-driven gender equitable change by partners and their networks		
# of downloads of related documentation from website and webinar views (disaggregated by country and region)	1500 downloads and 1000 views	Above target
Level of satisfaction with dissemination and learning opportunities reported by partners and their networks	75% of partners and their networks are satisfied	Above target

Finding: The project's flexible, partner-led design enhanced effectiveness by supporting contextual adaptation and responsiveness, while also introducing coordination and management complexity.

As discussed under Relevance, the project's flexible, partner-led design was a key strength that supported alignment with partner mandates and local priorities. Under Effectiveness, this flexibility also emerged as an important enabling factor for implementation and results achievement across diverse and evolving contexts. Partners consistently emphasized that the ability to adapt activities, timelines, and budgets in real time was critical to maintaining implementation during periods of disruption, including COVID-19, political instability, and insecurity. For example, reflecting on the reallocation of funds to support safer transportation for participants, one partner noted: "Because we had that flexibility and openness in how the project is managed, people understood the situation and were open to taking decisions together that would support successful implementation." This adaptability enabled partners to modify approaches based on emerging needs while maintaining continuity and relevance at the community level.

The project's decentralized and collaborative approach also enabled partners to tailor activities and priorities to their socio-cultural, political, and institutional contexts. Partners described having the autonomy to adapt, propose, and occasionally decline activities based on contextual realities, which strengthened ownership and responsiveness throughout implementation. In several contexts, this flexibility supported the integration of emerging priorities, including climate adaptation and crisis response, without fundamentally restructuring project activities.

At the same time, the breadth of activities and openness of the project design introduced coordination and management complexity. As one Coady staff member noted, "the management was a challenge at the beginning because there was a lot of complexity," given the diversity of approaches across countries. Another partner reflected:

With so many partners, activities, and learning opportunities happening at once, it could sometimes feel overwhelming. We had communities of practice, learning exchanges, and project management committee meetings all running in parallel. Because of staff attrition and the volume of activities, there were times when we couldn't fully engage in everything we wanted to.

These challenges did not undermine the overall effectiveness of the project, but they did highlight the institutional capacity and coordination required to operationalize highly participatory and adaptive multi-country programs effectively.

Finding: The project's emphasis on peer learning and exchange strengthened implementation effectiveness by enhancing organizational capacity and facilitating the

cross-fertilization of ideas, though access to these opportunities was uneven across partners.

The project's emphasis on peer learning and exchange among partners was a key driver of effectiveness, contributing to both organizational capacity development and implementation quality. Cross-partner learning was consistently identified by partner organizations as one of the most valuable aspects of ENGAGE, enabling the cross-fertilization of ideas through exposure to diverse models and practices. Peer learning took place through multiple mechanisms – including in-person and online courses, fellowships, exchange visits, learning forums, kitchen table talks, and communities of practice – which enabled partners to adapt and apply innovations developed elsewhere, strengthening implementation and increasing contextual relevance. For instance, exchanges with SEWA enabled WISE to upgrade its IT systems supporting savings and credit cooperatives in Ethiopia, while TGNP's expertise in gender-responsive budgeting informed integration into CCDB's programming in Bangladesh. As one Coady staff member noted, "lots of unexpected... [outcomes] came from partner to partner interaction," underscoring the organic and demand-driven nature of these processes.

In-person engagement emerged as particularly important for deeper learning and relationship-building. Partners emphasized that face-to-face exchanges supported stronger uptake and application of knowledge and skills than virtual modalities alone, while also building trust, solidarity, and mutual accountability. Peer learning thus functioned not only as a capacity-building mechanism, but also as a relational process that reinforced the collaborative character of the project. This aligns closely with feminist principles of knowledge co-creation and horizontal learning, recognizing partners as both knowledge holders and contributors.

While virtual modalities helped maintain continuity in project activities, they were not equally accessible to all partners due to connectivity constraints, costs, and time zone differences, which in some cases required participation late at night. As one partner noted, "for us this was a challenge... using devices for online sessions was difficult. Internet connectivity was also a problem." Participation in in-person exchanges was further constrained by external factors, including visa barriers and insecurity. As one partner noted:

Visas were a big challenge because the program involved a lot of travel. Getting Canadian visas was especially difficult. At one point an entire group of 15 members had their visas rejected. Some members were denied twice and may no longer be able to apply for a Canadian visa.

These challenges were particularly acute for some partners, such as CLE in Haiti, where insecurity and travel disruptions limited participation in project events, fellowships, and exchange visits central to the project's learning model.

Overall, the evidence indicates that peer learning and exchange were central to implementation effectiveness. However, uneven access to these mechanisms highlights how structural and logistical barriers shaped participation across partners.

Finding: The project's research and learning agenda contributed to knowledge generation and cross-partner learning, but its late formalization limited its effectiveness in early implementation.

The project's research and learning agenda – encompassing action research, case study documentation, curriculum development, fellowships, exchange visits, and learning forums – was widely valued by partners and supported meaningful knowledge generation and cross-context learning. A key strength of the research and learning agenda was its flexible and well-resourced design, which enabled partners to define context-specific priorities and pursue independent research aligned with their needs. Two complementary forms of research were embedded in the project design: partner-led individual research and more coordinated, collective learning processes. While individual research supported locally relevant inquiry, collective approaches were more effective in fostering cross-partner exchange and generating shared insights across contexts.

However, the learning agenda was not fully articulated or operationalized until later in the project, in Year 4 of implementation. In the early stages, limited clarity around processes and guidance meant that some research contributed less effectively to overall project objectives. As one Coady staff member reflected, there were “missed opportunities to link partner findings directly to broader project objectives,” including opportunities for cross-partner knowledge synthesis. The hiring of a dedicated Research Officer for the project in 2024 was reported to have strengthened coordination, clarified processes, and improved the alignment and integration of research activities across the project.

This trajectory also reflects a broader implementation dynamic: effective collaborative learning requires time to build relationships, trust, and shared priorities. Early in the project, partners were still establishing these foundations, which constrained the feasibility of a fully coherent and coordinated learning agenda. As relationships matured, improved coordination, clearer guidance, and a targeted training workshop on qualitative research ultimately strengthened the effectiveness and contribution of this pillar to learning outcomes. This highlights how early clarity and coordination shape the effectiveness of a shared learning agenda.

Finding: Coady was effective in its role as lead organization and convenor, leveraging longstanding partnerships to foster trust, collaboration, and a non-hierarchical approach.

Coady's effectiveness was underpinned by its longstanding relationships with all five partner organizations, some spanning decades. This history created a strong foundation of trust, shared values, and mutual understanding, enabling more effective collaboration from the

outset and reducing the need to establish new working norms. Partners consistently described the partnership model as distinctive and characterized by an absence of hierarchical dynamics, with one noting that “there is no superior or inferior... it was more on an equal level.”

Coady’s convening role also drew on its ABCD approach, which emphasized building on partners’ existing strengths, knowledge, and capacities. One Coady staff member explained that because partners “already had some familiarity with ABCD,” the project was able to move beyond introductory concepts and “engage more deeply with its application” in areas such as women’s agency, citizen-to-citizen accountability, and climate uncertainty. The project’s 6.5-year duration further reinforced these dynamics, allowing relationships and collaboration to deepen over time – an enabling factor that is relatively rare in comparable development programming.

Finding: External shocks constrained implementation and limited the scale, depth, and equity of results across contexts.

External shocks were a key constraining factor affecting the project’s ability to achieve results consistently across contexts. COVID-19 had an immediate and widespread impact in Year 1 – delaying activities, limiting in-person engagement, and requiring rapid shifts to remote delivery. While partners adapted quickly to online modalities, these were not equally accessible to all participants, particularly those with limited access to technology or connectivity. As a result, some activities were reduced in scale or effectiveness, especially in the early phases of the project.

Beyond the pandemic, political instability and insecurity further constrained implementation in several countries. In Haiti, for example, insecurity significantly limited mobility and participation in both national and international activities, resulting in consistently lower engagement. In other contexts, shrinking civic space and political volatility also affected implementation. As one partner described, “the civil space has shrunk to the maximum... women leaders have been targeted... we are now in a transition period,” highlighting the risks faced by organizations and participants.

As previously noted, barriers to international travel, particularly visa restrictions, further limited participation in cross-partner learning and exchange. Partners described repeated challenges in securing visas to Canada, with one noting that “at one point an entire group of 15 members had their visas rejected,” while others reported that only a fraction of intended participants were able to travel. In other cases, participation was constrained by political instability and insecurity. For example, partners from TGNP were unable to attend a Feminist MEL workshop due to unrest associated with national elections in Tanzania. While virtual alternatives provided some continuity, they were not a full substitute for in-person engagement.

Finding: Deeply rooted patriarchal norms and cultural resistance shaped the pace of change, while the project helped sustain women's participation and leadership in challenging contexts.

Gendered structural constraints affected both the depth and sustainability of outcomes. Across contexts, partners described deeply rooted norms that limited women's participation in economic activities and leadership roles. As one noted, "traditional gender roles limited acceptance of women's leadership, and shifting mindsets was a gradual process," while another highlighted that in some communities, women were not permitted to participate in activities or take on leadership roles due to male-dominated norms.

Resistance was evident at multiple levels. At the household level, one partner organization shared, "women members faced resistance from their male counterparts," requiring additional sensitization efforts to enable participation. At the community level, restrictive norms around women's mobility and public engagement limited uptake of project activities. In institutional settings, limited initial support from local government actors further slowed progress. One partner reflected that gender-responsive budgeting "remains under-prioritized... and it took time to motivate [officials] to develop budgets in consultation with women."

These constraints shaped both the pace and extent of change. While the project contributed to gradual shifts in attitudes and practices, progress was uneven and required sustained effort, reflecting the deeply embedded nature of patriarchal norms. Multiple partners also emphasized that the project was implemented within broader contexts of increasing social and political backlash and resistance to gender equality. In this context, sustaining women's participation, leadership, and collective engagement represented an important achievement and foundation for longer-term transformation.

Finding: Staffing gaps and leadership turnover intermittently disrupted coordination and implementation, but also created opportunities for organizational renewal and strengthened gender alignment.

Staffing gaps and turnover across both Coady and partner organizations were identified as a recurring challenge affecting implementation. Changes in key roles (including project management, MEL, and research positions at Coady) created periods of disruption, particularly in relation to coordination, institutional memory, and internal learning processes. For example, multiple partners noted that they had requested capacity-building in feminist MEL approaches; however, in the absence of a dedicated MEL Officer for much of the project, this training was not provided until Year 5, limiting its relevance for earlier implementation phases.

At the partner level, turnover and leadership changes were also widespread. As highlighted during the validation workshop, nearly all partner organizations experienced some form of leadership transition over the course of the project. These shifts introduced additional

pressures, particularly where institutional knowledge was lost or where new leadership required time to build relationships and align with project approaches. In a complex, multi-country program reliant on sustained collaboration and shared understanding, these disruptions affected coordination and, at times, the consistency of implementation.

However, these transitions were not solely constraining. In fact, in several cases, leadership changes created openings for organizational renewal and shifts in direction. Notably, some partners highlighted transitions from male to female leadership, aligning more closely with the project's gender equality objectives and, in some cases, strengthening institutional commitment to women's empowerment. These dynamics illustrate how organizational change, while disruptive, can also create opportunities to advance gender-transformative outcomes.

6.3 Efficiency

To what extent were project activities implemented in a timely and cost-efficient manner, and what lessons can inform improvements in efficiency for similar initiatives?

Finding: COVID-19 disrupted implementation efficiency by extending timelines and increasing delivery complexity, though impacts were mitigated through adaptive management and partner agility.

The COVID-19 pandemic disrupted implementation timelines and reduced delivery efficiency, requiring real-time adaptations, shifts to remote and hybrid modalities, and increased coordination to sustain activity delivery. These adjustments extended timelines and increased the effort required to achieve planned outputs, particularly in contexts with limited digital access.

As project documentation shows, the pandemic had an immediate impact from Year 1 of implementation. For example, COVID-19 delayed core start-up activities, including completion of the baseline study and rollout of initial community-based activities, while constraining travel and in-person engagement.³ These disruptions contributed to an initial underspend, as planned in-person activities were cancelled or postponed (e.g. an in-person workshop to test data collection tools with partners, baseline data collection in implementation countries). Ongoing restrictions required activities to be deferred, reduced in scale, or adapted to remote formats, increasing coordination demands and delivery time. As one Coady staff member reflected, “the pandemic disrupted a lot of the early coordination structures.”

³ ENGAGE! Women's Empowerment and Active Citizenship Annual Work Plan 2021-2022

Partners demonstrated agility and responsiveness, adapting delivery modalities and maintaining engagement despite ongoing constraints. They transitioned to remote support, leveraged online platforms for training and exchange, and reassessed which activities were best suited to virtual or in-person delivery. As one partner organization noted, “because we were agile.. it allowed us to pivot rapidly and to face those challenges, particularly to address the needs of the women that we were working with.”

In parallel, partners responded to urgent community needs arising from the pandemic, in some cases temporarily reprioritizing activities to support vulnerable groups. For example, SEWA conducted a survey with over 1,800 members, which found that 67% of informal worker households had lost livelihoods due to COVID-19 and fewer than 34% had received government cash benefits, often due to lack of registration.⁴ While many of the associated emergency response activities were implemented through SEWA’s Livelihoods Recovery and Rehabilitation Fund supported by the COMART Foundation, respondents emphasized that ENGAGE contributed important organizational and technical capacity strengthening that enabled rapid response and coordination during the crisis. As one SEWA staff member explained, the program strengthened technical and coordination capacities, supporting remote data collection, advocacy, and broader response efforts related to cash transfers, banking access, and food relief. They reflected, “Much of this rapid advocacy and coordination during COVID-19 was made possible because of ENGAGE.” These examples illustrate how project investments strengthened partners’ institutional capacities and adaptability, enabling them to respond quickly and effectively during periods of crisis, even where response activities extended beyond the formal scope of the ENGAGE project.

Overall, while COVID-19 reduced short-term implementation efficiency by extending timelines and increasing delivery complexity, the project’s adaptive design, supported by partner responsiveness and GAC’s flexible risk management approach, including approval of a no-cost extension, was critical to sustaining implementation across contexts.

“Because we were agile, because the project was managed and implemented in an agile manner, it allowed us to pivot rapidly and face those challenges, particularly to address the needs of the women we were working with.”

– ENGAGE Partner Organization Staff

Finding: External pressures reduced cost-efficiency, but were effectively managed within the overall budget through adaptive financial planning.

As noted earlier, COVID-19-related delays in the early stages of implementation contributed to initial underspending, with funds subsequently rolled over and later absorbed as activities scaled up in subsequent years.⁵ As in-person delivery resumed, costs increased, particularly

⁴ ENGAGE! Baseline Report. Annex G: SEWA Baseline

⁵ ENGAGE! Annual Work Plan 2021-2022 and 2022-2023

for international and in-country travel, alongside broader inflationary pressures affecting goods, services, and operations. While these shifts resulted in higher-than-anticipated costs, they did not lead to budget overruns but instead created budgetary pressures requiring ongoing monitoring and adjustment.

Inflation and currency volatility

Inflation and exchange rate fluctuations were persistent risks across implementation countries, increasing the cost of goods, services, and local operations over time. In some contexts, currency depreciation reduced the value of transferred funds, requiring budget adjustments to maintain planned activity levels. In response, Coady and partners applied mitigation strategies, including holding funds in more stable currencies (e.g., USD or CAD), where permitted, and transferring to local currency as needed.⁶ Quarterly financial reporting and advance transfer mechanisms further supported budget predictability and reduced exposure to exchange rate volatility.

Travel costs and insecurity

Rising and unpredictable travel costs also posed challenges, driven by shifting visa requirements, airline availability, price volatility, and deteriorating security conditions in some contexts. These factors altered cost assumptions and, in some cases, required substantial changes to delivery logistics. As one partner staff member explained:

When we were planning for this program, as a country we could move around and take a bus that would cost \$10 to move a participant from point A to point B. Once we started actually implementing the program, we had our massive insecurity situation and the only way to move people around was to actually fly people. So our costs shifted from \$10 for travel to \$300 per travel, per participant, creating a massive budget shift.

Climate-related and market disruptions

In addition, climate-related shocks and broader instability contributed to localized disruptions in markets and supply chains, affecting the availability and cost of inputs for project activities. While evidence in this area is more limited, partners noted during the validation workshop that extreme weather events and related disruptions increased operational uncertainty and, in some cases, required adjustments to activity timing or delivery. One partner also highlighted that climate shocks are increasingly interconnected with technological disruptions, further compounding risks to implementation and requiring greater flexibility in planning and delivery.

⁶ ENGAGE! Annual Work Plan 2024-2025

These external pressures reduced cost-efficiency, as more resources were required to deliver activities at the same scale. However, there is limited evidence that core activities were significantly reduced. Instead, partners adapted delivery modalities and prioritized activities in response to evolving constraints.

The project managed these pressures through adaptive financial management, including budget realignment and the use of a no-cost extension from GAC, enabling it to respond to shifting timelines and rising costs while remaining within the approved budget envelope. Overall, while cost-efficiency was constrained by external conditions, proactive financial management and flexibility allowed the project to absorb shocks without compromising delivery, underscoring the importance of adaptive budgeting in volatile operating environments.

6.4 Coherence

To what extent did the project complement other gender equity initiatives in the countries of focus, and avoid duplication or overlap?

Finding: The project aligned with local and national gender equality priorities, primarily functioning as an implementation and amplification mechanism rather than shaping policy directions.

Across implementation countries, the project's objectives and activities were largely consistent with existing local and national government priorities related to women's empowerment, such as economic participation, entrepreneurship, increased representation in leadership and decision-making spaces, and prevention of child marriage. Partners noted that training on economic skills and advocacy "is fully aligned with the government's priority policies," and that project activities supported women in becoming more economically self-reliant and aware of their rights.

This alignment extended to broader governance frameworks, such as community participation in planning and gender-responsive budgeting. In some cases, project approaches were used or adapted by local government actors to mobilize communities or support local development initiatives. For example, knowledge centers and community groups were engaged in discussions around infrastructure and environmental priorities, indicating overlap between project activities and local governance processes. Likewise, this alignment reflects that the project largely operated within existing policy directions rather than shaping new ones. While it contributed to implementation at the community level, there is limited evidence that it systematically influenced policy design or addressed gaps in areas where government engagement was weaker. In some contexts, partner organizations and participants also noted that local government actors were not supportive or difficult to engage, particularly on issues such as gender-based violence, which constrained the extent to which alignment translated into coordinated action.

Finding: The project complemented existing NGO and donor initiatives by emphasizing group formation, collective action, and peer-based learning, while most other interventions remained oriented toward individual service delivery.

Interview and SGD respondents frequently distinguished ENGAGE's approach from that of other local organizations working on gender equality. Many gender-focused NGO and donor initiatives across the countries of focus provide services such as microcredit, legal assistance, and entrepreneurship, or health support, often targeting individuals. In contrast, the project prioritized group formation, collective action, and peer-based learning.

The project's focus on organizing women into groups – such as cooperatives, knowledge centers, and SACCOs – enabled different forms of engagement. Participants described how these groups supported not only individual members but also facilitated the diffusion of knowledge and practices within the wider community. In Tanzania, participants observed that groups formed through other initiatives are often primarily vehicles for accessing loans, but these groups “may hardly know each other and may not share a common cause.” Participants contrasted this with the project's emphasis on building relationships, shared purpose, and collaboration within groups, contributing to cohesion and collective identity. As one participant noted:

TGNP has taught us how to form groups, how to sit together, and how to be a collective. The time and resources the government does not have. Projects do well because group members know each other and have invested time in the collective.

This distinction shaped the type of outcomes observed. Collective structures enabled women to engage in advocacy, mobilize communities, and influence local decision-making processes in ways that individual-level interventions typically do not. In fact, the project did not replace the need for services provided by other actors. Participants frequently emphasized the importance of continued linkages with organizations offering legal support, financial services, and other specialized expertise, indicating that the project functioned as a complementary layer within the broader ecosystem, demonstrating coherence through complementarity rather than duplication.

Finding: The project functioned as a connector across actors and initiatives, facilitating access to resources, partnerships, and support beyond its direct scope.

A recurring theme across interviews and SGDs was the project's role in building connections between partner organizations, participants, and external actors across the countries of focus. Interview and SGD respondents described how networks created through the project enabled access to opportunities, information, and support not directly provided by ENGAGE. One local organization noted that the network functioned as “a family” and that “if I need

something, I know where I can go,” while others highlighted how the project strengthened their ability to connect with individuals across regions and sectors.

In Haiti, this connector role was particularly evident through CLE’s involvement in ANTREPRANN, a collective platform bringing together over ten entrepreneurship-support organizations with the explicit purpose of centralizing resources, opportunities, and services for entrepreneurs. Through this platform, CLE was described as facilitating access to resources beyond the project, including training, legal advice, and business development support. As one local partner of CLE explained:

There are resources that are not necessarily inside ENGAGE itself, but they can be accessed through the ANTREPRANN platform. CLE can open that path, and ANTREPRANN can also open paths toward training, information, and other opportunities. So there is a transfer of opportunities, a transfer of skills, and a collaboration that can help entrepreneurs not have to run everywhere from one institution to another. In that way, something different is being offered.

This account illustrates how the platform functioned as a bridge, reducing fragmentation and enabling access to opportunities and skills across institutions. At the organizational level, these connections led to new collaborations, including joint initiatives and partnerships that continued independently of the project. This connector role in Haiti was not informal or incidental but embedded within a deliberately co-constructed ecosystem.

This bridging role also highlighted the importance of interconnected support systems and coordination across civil society actors. Participants noted that in areas such as conflict resolution or legal support, meaningful support often depended on collaboration with specialized organizations and referral networks beyond the direct scope of the project. In several contexts, these linkages strengthened participants’ access to services, information, and opportunities that no single organization could provide alone. However, the extent to which these connections translated into coordinated and reliable support varied across contexts, with some linkages remaining informal or underdeveloped. This points to uneven levels of integration within the broader ecosystem and highlights the importance of sustained coordination and partnership-building across sectors and institutions.

Finding: The project addressed gaps in capacity-building and facilitation approaches for participants engaged in training and advocacy activities, while relying on other actors to provide complementary technical and service-based support.

Interview and SGD respondents identified several areas where the project filled gaps not fully addressed by other local initiatives, particularly in relation to facilitation techniques, advocacy, and applied skills among participants. Participants described gaining new tools and approaches through ENGAGE-supported training, including conflict resolution, community engagement, and participatory methods. One respondent noted the

importance of “learning new skills and how other people globally are doing their work,” indicating exposure to practices beyond local contexts.

Participants often applied these capacities in practice, though not without challenges. For example, some participants attempting to use conflict resolution techniques found it difficult to address complex cases without additional support, highlighting the limits of training in the absence of specialized expertise. This led to recognition of the need to collaborate with organizations providing legal or professional services. This dynamic reflects a division of roles within the ecosystem. The project focused on building foundational skills and capacities, while other actors provided more specialized or resource-intensive services. In practice, the effectiveness of this complementarity depended on the availability and accessibility of these external services, which varied across contexts.

Finding: The project operated within local ecosystems of actors and initiatives, where outcomes were shaped through interaction and synergy rather than clearly attributable to a single intervention.

Interview and SGD respondents consistently described gender equality outcomes from ENGAGE as emerging through interaction among multiple actors, including NGOs, government institutions, networks, and community groups. Within this landscape, the project was understood as one of several complementary initiatives rather than a standalone intervention. As one respondent in Haiti noted, “changes do not come from CLE alone, but also from the synergy among actors [...] working in the same field.”

This was further reflected in participants’ descriptions of their experiences, where project activities often intersected with and reinforced other initiatives, including government programs, advocacy efforts, and community-based projects led by local organizations. In some cases, project approaches and capacities were adopted or integrated within broader efforts – such as policy advocacy, community mobilization, and service delivery – contributing to shared outcomes across actors.

As a result, observed changes cannot be attributed solely to the project, but rather reflect its contribution within a wider system of actors and interventions. This highlights the project’s role within a collective effort toward gender equality, where coherence is expressed through alignment, interaction, and mutual reinforcement across initiatives.

Finding: While the project generally avoided direct duplication of activities, coordination challenges and uneven engagement with key actors limited coherence in practice.

The evaluation found limited evidence of direct duplication with other initiatives. Interview and SGD respondents did not report overlap in service delivery or competition with other actors. Instead, the project tended to operate in areas that complemented existing efforts, such as group formation, training, and networking. However, this complementarity was not

always fully realized in practice. Coordination challenges were noted, particularly in relation to engagement with local government actors and the integration of different project components. Some respondents described difficulties in working with local leaders, noting that collaboration was constrained by political dynamics and competing interests. In other cases, coordination mechanisms within the project were not fully operationalized, affecting information flow and alignment across partners. While these factors did not lead to duplication, they limited the extent to which the project was strategically aligned and coordinated with other actors.

In contexts where relationships and coordination were stronger, complementarity was more fully realized; where coordination was weaker, the project operated more independently within the broader ecosystem. In Haiti, constraints on coherence were shaped in part by the security situation. CLE was rarely visited in person by other project partners, with most coordination occurring online. Participants from Haiti were often unable to attend in-person activities held in other countries due to travel restrictions and security concerns, limiting their ability to engage in cross-partner learning and exchange. While this did not undermine coherence within Haiti's own ecosystem – where CLE maintained strong relationships with local actors – it did constrain the extent to which Haiti's experience was integrated into wider coordination processes across the partnership.

6.5 Impact

To what extent has the project contributed to women's and girls' empowerment and active citizenship in the five target countries, and what lessons can be drawn to improve impact in similar initiatives?

Finding: The project contributed strongly to women's self-confidence, voice, and agency, while broader structural shifts in power relations remained gradual and uneven.

Across the interview and SGD data, the most consistent contribution of the project was at the level of self-confidence. In the five target countries, women and girls described increased confidence and ability to speak in public, participate in meetings and community forums, approach local institutions and actors, and express their views within families and communities. For some, this shift was described in very concrete terms. One participant explained, "Now I have much more confidence. Whether it is an online meeting or an offline meeting, I can participate and speak in front of others. Earlier I did not have that confidence." Another participant recollected:

I used to sit at the back during trainings and rarely speak. One day, the trainer handed me the microphone and encouraged me to say something. I was so nervous, my voice was trembling. But over time, I

gained confidence. Now I can speak freely with others and talk in front of people using a microphone.

These accounts demonstrate increased confidence and agency, supporting more active participation in social and community life.

In settings where women's mobility and visibility were heavily constrained, these changes were particularly significant. In Bangladesh, for example, interviewees noted that project activities provided women – many of whom had never left their homes independently prior to participating in ENGAGE – with “safe, legitimate reasons to travel” and interact with project staff, local officials, and other actors, expanding their presence in public spaces. Similar patterns emerged elsewhere, where women described confidence to move beyond the home and engage more actively in community life. As one participant from India noted, “Before, I was afraid to go outside and did not know how to travel anywhere. After the training, I gained courage. I started attending meetings and coming regularly, and this increased my confidence. Now I can go anywhere easily.” These changes reflect meaningful, though contextually bounded, shifts in women's agency and freedom of movement, even within restrictive social contexts.

The data suggests that empowerment in these contexts was most clearly expressed through changes in confidence, voice, agency, and participation in public and community life. Across countries, women described feeling more able to speak, travel independently, engage with institutions, participate in collective activities, and navigate spaces that had previously felt inaccessible. In many cases, these shifts were particularly significant within contexts where women's mobility, visibility, and participation had historically been constrained. At the same time, broader transformations in institutional and structural power relations often require sustained, long-term engagement beyond the lifespan of a single project. While the evidence of deeper shifts in control over resources, decision-making authority, and institutional power was more uneven across contexts, the changes documented through ENGAGE represent important foundations for longer-term social transformation.

“I used to sit at the back during trainings and rarely speak. One day, the trainer handed me the microphone and encouraged me to say something. I was so nervous, my voice was trembling. But over time, I gained confidence. Now I can speak freely with others and talk in front of people using a microphone.”

– ENGAGE Community-Based Training Participant

Finding: The project strengthened women's leadership and active citizenship at the community level, contributing to meaningful shifts in civic participation and community influence across contexts.

Across contexts, the evaluation found that women participants increasingly engaged with local authorities and institutions, with growing participation and influence in community governance structures (e.g., schools, health, and local committees) and decision-making processes. In SGDs, participants described attending and speaking in community meetings, building relationships with local leaders, and raising awareness of the needs and priorities of women and girls through advocacy and direct engagement. They consistently attributed these changes to ENGAGE-supported training, advocacy, and peer support networks, which strengthened their confidence, skills, and ability to engage in public and institutional spaces.

The evaluation also found concrete examples of women moving into visible leadership and civic roles that were previously inaccessible to them. In Bangladesh, women who had not participated in formal structures prior to the project were elected into community committees and began engaging directly with local government representatives. One participant described how women “are now involved in the decision making process not only at family level but also at community level” and are interacting with government officials to access services. In at least one case, a participant ran for local government office, losing by a narrow margin, indicating both increased confidence and a shift in what is perceived as possible for women in these contexts.

In Tanzania, examples of leadership were more clearly expressed through collective organizing and representation. One participant became chair of the Street Traders Association, while another emerged as a district-level spokesperson for street vendors. These roles involved engaging parliamentarians and contributing to efforts that led to reduced harassment of street vendors. As one participant described, “These vendors were being highly abused in areas of road junctions. We succeeded in raising a loud voice about that issue.” Other examples included more strategic use of “community parliament” mechanisms, resulting in tangible outcomes such as the establishment of a dispensary in Saranga Ward. These cases suggest movement beyond individual confidence toward organized, issue-based civic engagement.

There are also examples of women taking on intermediary and facilitative roles within their communities. In Bangladesh, participants accompanied seriously ill individuals to Social Welfare Offices to access medical assistance, navigating bureaucratic processes on their behalf. As a result, the community “now understands that women members of the ENGAGE program are capable of speaking confidently in any office or court to resolve issues.” In other cases, women organized local service delivery initiatives, such as low-cost cervical cancer screening, facilitated access to government incentives, and supported peers in navigating institutions. In India, SEWA Master Trainers moved into formal roles in village-level committees, with some local institutions proactively inviting them to lead awareness

activities. These examples reflect forms of active citizenship grounded in problem-solving, service facilitation, and community-level leadership.

At the same time, the depth and consistency of women's engagement varied across contexts due to structural and gender-related barriers, including limited access to resources and persistent social norms. Across interviews, respondents described deeply rooted patriarchal norms and cultural resistance that constrained women's participation in leadership and public life. In some contexts, women faced resistance from male household members, limiting their ability to engage in project activities, while in others, restrictive norms made it difficult for women to take on leadership roles or participate outside the home. As one respondent noted, "traditional gender roles limited acceptance of women's leadership, and shifting mindsets was a gradual process," while another emphasized that "women are very suppressed by their male partners... it is not acceptable... for women to work outside the home." At the institutional level, limited initial support from local government actors further constrained engagement in different contexts.

These constraints influenced the pace, depth, and sustainability of change. While women across contexts demonstrated increased participation and leadership at the community level, the depth and sustainability of progress varied and often required ongoing negotiation within households and institutions. Some participants expressed a desire for expanded project activities, including greater engagement with men, youth, and duty bearers, to support more sustained and inclusive change. Despite these challenges, women described a strong sense of ownership over their progress and their intention to continue advocacy and community engagement beyond the project. These gains were most visible at the community and local governance levels, where women increasingly engaged in leadership, advocacy, and service facilitation roles. While broader institutional and systemic shifts in power and decision-making typically require sustained engagement over longer periods of time, the project contributed important foundations for continued women's leadership, civic participation, and collective action across contexts.

Finding: The project contributed to shifts in household gender relations, particularly in communication and decision-making, though women's increased influence was often tied to their economic contributions.

Across implementation countries, interviews and SGDs linked project participation to changes within households, particularly in communication, decision-making, and perceptions of women's roles. Many women participants described more open dialogue with spouses and increased inclusion in household decisions related to income, expenditures, and family wellbeing. These shifts were often reflected in everyday interactions. In Bangladesh, for example, participants noted that whereas previously a woman questioning household purchases could lead to conflict or even physical reprimand, husbands now consult their wives directly – calling from the market to ask what should be bought – and increasingly value their input, reflecting a shift toward more consultative and inclusive household decision-making. Women's perspectives are now more commonly

considered not only in day-to-day spending but also in decisions related to larger assets such as land or livestock.

Women also reported being more able to speak openly at home and influence key household decisions. In India, one SEWA member shared, “I did not believe I could do something like this, but after the training my confidence increased and I spoke at home,” which contributed to “major decisions about loans and building a permanent house”. Another SEWA member stated “At home and in the village, my respect has increased because I earn and participate in community work.” Across contexts, respondents described husbands becoming more consultative and supportive, with women’s perspectives increasingly recognized in family matters.

Additional evidence from WISE’s action-based research in Ethiopia also points to shifts in household decision-making, bargaining power, and experiences of domestic violence linked to women’s economic empowerment and participation in SACCOs.⁷ The study found that women participating in WISE SACCOs demonstrated significantly higher levels of economic empowerment compared to non-members and reported substantially lower levels of physical abuse. Qualitative findings from this research further suggest that increased income, access to savings and loans, leadership development, and strengthened self-confidence contributed to greater decision-making power within households and improved ability to negotiate gender relations.

However, these shifts were not uniform and, in some cases, introduced new tensions. As women became more engaged in income-generating activities, some respondents observed that men reduced their own contributions to household responsibilities. This dynamic increased the overall burden on women, who described managing income generation alongside existing domestic and caregiving roles. In some cases, this created trade-offs, including reduced time for family responsibilities such as supporting children’s education. These findings suggest that while women’s roles and participation expanded, this was not always accompanied by a redistribution of labour within the household.

The evidence also suggests that many of these changes were closely linked to women’s economic contributions and perceived value within the household. Women participants frequently associated their increased voice and influence with income generation and contributions to household wellbeing and resilience. As one participant noted, “money empowers one’s position in the world.” This suggests that while economic participation created important openings for greater voice and negotiation within households, these changes were not always accompanied by broader shifts toward acceptance of women’s rights, autonomy, and equal authority.

⁷ Assessment of Women’s Economic Empowerment and Domestic Violence: The Case of WISE SACCO’s (2025)

Overall, the project contributed to meaningful improvements in household communication, women's participation in decision-making, and, in some cases, reductions in domestic violence. These changes often reflected incremental shifts within existing gender relations that were closely tied to women's economic contributions rather than deeper transformation of household power dynamics. Gains in voice, inclusion, and bargaining power therefore remain uneven and potentially fragile.

Finding: Economic empowerment was a key pathway to women's empowerment and public participation, though links to broader collective and political change were uneven across contexts.

The evaluation data consistently links empowerment to women's income generation, entrepreneurship, business formalisation, and financial inclusion. Women were described as becoming earners, opening bank accounts, improving business practices, and moving toward more formal and recognized economic activities. In some cases, this reduced dependence and expanded women's choices. One participant noted that women had become "more autonomous, more financially independent, and more formalized in their businesses," while others linked income generation to improved food security, resilience, and reduced child labour.

Economic activity also served as a platform for public participation. Women engaged with market committees, joined producer networks, exhibited products, interacted with local government officials and national ministers, and connected with regional associations such as the African Women in Processing Network. In some cases, entrepreneurship training was explicitly linked to activism and community influence, based on the view that having an income-generating activity can strengthen women's ability to engage in activism and community leadership. This suggests that the project positioned economic advancement not as separate from citizenship, but as one pathway into public legitimacy and leadership.

The evidence suggests that economic gains did not translate uniformly into stronger bargaining power across domains or collective political agency. For some women, enterprise growth enhanced confidence and visibility; for others, outcomes remained closer to improved livelihoods than broader empowerment. External barriers, including market and regulatory constraints, also continued to limit how these gains could be leveraged. As a result, while economic empowerment was one of the project's strongest contribution pathways, the extent to which this contributed to broader collective and political transformation varied across contexts.

Finding: The project contributed to collective action and rights-claiming across several contexts, though these dimensions of active citizenship developed unevenly across the portfolio.

Among the stronger examples of collective and rights-based engagement in the evaluation data are cases where women and girls organized around shared issues, not only individual

advancement. Participants described women using community parliament structures, advocating against harassment, engaging parliamentarians, confronting gender-based violence and female genital mutilation/cutting, challenging wage discrimination, and organizing for school re-entry and girls' rights. In Tanzania, TGNP's knowledge centers successfully advocated for the construction of a dedicated hospital service window for elderly people, which was subsequently implemented by the health facility. Knowledge center members were also formally invited to present on gender-responsive budgeting at budgeting meetings in Kishapu, and TGNP supported women in successfully contesting leadership positions in the 2024 local government elections.⁸ There are also examples of girls using social media for advocacy and becoming "better organized for collective action around various challenges facing girls." These cases go beyond confidence-building and point toward a more political form of active citizenship, in which women and girls act collectively to address exclusion and injustice.

This is important because it suggests that the project's contribution was not confined to personal development or livelihood gains. In some contexts, it supported women and girls to identify shared grievances, mobilize collectively, and engage institutions to press for change. Where this occurred, the link between empowerment and active citizenship was especially evident, and the project appeared most effective when training, organizational support, and issue-based mobilisation came together. However, these examples were more strongly reflected in some partner contexts than others, rather than consistently across the program as a whole.

Finding: Participation in Coady and partner-led courses strengthened capacity to advance women's and girls' empowerment and active citizenship among partner organizations and their networks.

The evaluation found that capacity-building support provided through Coady and partner-led courses contributed to strengthened organizational knowledge, skills, and approaches related to gender equality, participatory development, and active citizenship. Courses on ABCD, feminist advocacy, social accountability, development leadership, and project planning were widely seen as relevant and practical, supporting both individual learning and broader organizational application.

Participation in these courses enabled partner organization staff and their networks to strengthen technical competencies (e.g., gender-responsive programming, advocacy, and planning), as well as facilitation and training skills. The opportunity for partners to co-design and co-deliver courses – such as the community-led climate solutions course co-led by CCDB and TGNP's module on gender-responsive budgeting – further deepened capacity in curriculum development, contextual adaptation, and peer learning. This reflects the value of Coady's role as a learning partner, rather than solely a training provider.

⁸ ENGAGE! Annual Report (2025). Annex 12: TGNP Results Report.

Across SGDs, partner staff described motivations for participation as both professional and personal: building knowledge and practical tools, strengthening facilitation skills, and supporting career development, networking, and relationship-building. Courses were consistently described as highly applicable, with participants emphasizing their ability to translate learning into practice. As one participant noted, “the courses have been structured in a way that you can apply them to the community or to the issues related to what we are doing,” underscoring their practical relevance.

In several cases, partners demonstrated strengthened capacity to support women’s leadership and participatory approaches at the community level, including applying ABCD tools to mobilize local assets and adapting facilitation techniques to improve engagement and understanding among women participants. One participant highlighted the practical application of course content, noting that training on tools for working with young women helped “engage with young women in unleashing their potential for leadership and also enhancing their confidence,” illustrating how learning directly supported gender-transformative approaches in practice.

Interview and SGD respondents also reflected that over time, Coady course delivery evolved from more standardized offerings to increasingly tailored, demand-driven, and regionally delivered formats, including expanded in-person opportunities (post COVID-19). Greater partner involvement in shaping and leading courses marked a shift toward increased ownership and alignment with organizational priorities. Yet, accessibility and learning experiences varied across contexts and delivery formats. Some participants noted limitations related to contextual relevance, language barriers, and delivery modalities. Online courses, in particular, faced connectivity challenges and time zone constraints, while in-person formats were generally preferred for deeper learning and peer exchange.

6.6 Sustainability

To what extent are project results likely to be sustained by participants, partners, and communities, and what factors support or constrain their sustainability?

Participants

Finding: Community-based training participants continue to apply practical tools and techniques in their daily livelihoods and work, particularly where tools are simple, accessible, and linked to tangible benefits.

Participants described ongoing use of concrete tools introduced through the project, particularly practical business and livelihood skills that support income generation, asset-building, and women’s financial independence. In Haiti, sustained use was particularly visible in financial management and record-keeping practices, with participants describing how financial discipline became embedded in their daily routines. One participant explained

how they regularly used Excel to track purchases, stock, entries, and exits as part of routine business management. In Bangladesh, participants in agricultural training similarly described continuing to apply techniques such as vermicompost, natural pesticides, and crop diversification because of their low cost and visible economic benefits.

Sustained use was strongest where tools produced immediate and visible benefits. In livelihood contexts, participants linked continued use to improved yields, increased income, and better product quality. This suggests that sustainability at the individual level is closely tied to perceived usefulness and practical relevance, rather than to the comprehensiveness of the training itself.

Finding: Mindset shifts toward asset-based and participatory approaches are widely internalized by participants, contributing to changes in confidence, problem-solving, and community engagement practices.

Participants repeatedly described a shift in how they interpret and engage with community contexts, particularly through the adoption of ABCD approaches. These changes were framed not simply as the acquisition of new skills, but as a broader reorientation in thinking and practice. As one participant explained, prior to the training they focused on “what was negative,” whereas they now begin by identifying “the positive side, the existing resources, and what can be used.” Another participant described ABCD as having changed “both my approach and mindset.”

In some cases, participants described these shifts as reshaping assumptions about what is required to take action. As one participant in Tanzania reflected, “Personally, ABCD changed how I think about resources. In the past I believed I needed a lot of money before starting something meaningful. Now I start with whatever I have.” Participants also linked these changes in perspective to more participatory and confidence-based approaches in their work and community engagement activities.

While these mindset shifts were widely described, the extent to which they translated into sustained practice varied across contexts and individuals. In many cases, participants described applying participatory and asset-based approaches in their daily interactions, workplace activities, and community roles, while in others, continued application appeared to depend on ongoing opportunities, support networks, and enabling local environments. This suggests that while conceptual adoption was strong, the long-term operationalization of these approaches remained shaped by contextual and practical constraints.

“In the past I believed I needed a lot of money before starting something meaningful. Now I start with whatever I have.”

– ENGAGE Community-Based Training Participant

Communities

Finding: Knowledge and practices introduced through the project are being actively replicated within communities, with participants serving as key intermediaries for local knowledge diffusion.

Participants described efforts to share knowledge within their communities, often through informal and practice-based approaches. This includes demonstrations, peer training, and everyday interactions that allow others to observe and adopt new techniques. One participant captured this dynamic: “Every time we share with the community what we have learned [...] they replicate what we have taught [...] their economic lives improve.”

Replication is particularly evident in agricultural and livelihood practices. Community members have adopted techniques such as vermicomposting, natural pesticide preparation, and improved livestock management, often with visible results. In some cases, participants described facilitating structured peer learning by identifying skilled individuals within communities and redistributing their expertise: “We take a database of who is most skillful [...] and relocate them to train others [...] just make a system to learn from each other.” These dynamics indicate that knowledge transfer is occurring and adapting to local contexts.

“Even when the project ends, the work does not stop. The knowledge, the skills, and the structures we built are still being used every day in our communities.”

– ENGAGE Partner Organization

Partner Organizations

Finding: Partner organizations have sustained and new integrated approaches and organizational practices introduced through ENGAGE, although the depth of institutionalization varies across contexts and areas of work.

Multiple partners described deliberate efforts to integrate learning from ENGAGE into their organizational systems and ongoing programming. For instance, one organization emphasized that “everything we developed [...] was done with the intention of institutionalizing it,” including training modules, research methods, and facilitation practices. Others highlighted how approaches such as ABCD have been expanded into new projects and thematic areas, positioning the organization as a leader in this space. These examples suggest that ENGAGE contributed to sustained changes in organizational practice, particularly in areas related to participatory facilitation, community engagement, and program design.

Partner organizations also described ongoing changes in how they design proposals, facilitate discussions, and develop research and learning tools. One staff member noted that the training influenced how they formulate research questions, emphasizing clarity, accessibility, and depth of response. Others linked the project to increased confidence in facilitation and leadership roles, particularly in engaging grassroots women through participatory and visual methods. As one staff member explained, “We also make them stand up and participate actively [...] they enjoy learning this way.”

There is also evidence of cross-organizational learning and systems strengthening being sustained beyond the immediate project activities. As previously mentioned, exchanges with SEWA enabled WISE to strengthen its IT systems supporting savings and credit cooperatives in Ethiopia, while TGNP’s expertise in gender-responsive budgeting informed integration into CCDB’s programming in Bangladesh. These examples indicate that knowledge exchange between partners contributed not only to individual learning, but also to the adaptation and strengthening of organizational systems and approaches across contexts.

At the same time, the extent of institutionalization varied across different types of knowledge and organizational functions. Practices that were relatively simple, low-cost, and easily integrated into existing workflows demonstrated the strongest continuity over time. In contrast, more technically demanding components, particularly research and knowledge production, showed less consistent long-term uptake. In some cases, organizations continued to rely on external consultants for research-related activities, and certain outputs were perceived primarily as donor-oriented products rather than fully embedded internal practices. Follow-through on action research activities also appeared to vary depending on organizational capacity, staff time, and available resources.

Overall, the findings suggest that sustainability was strongest where project approaches aligned closely with existing organizational priorities, capacities, and operational realities. ENGAGE appears to have contributed to lasting changes in facilitation approaches, participatory engagement practices, and selected organizational systems, while also highlighting the additional time, resources, and institutional support often required to sustain more resource-intensive and technically specialized functions over the longer term.

Finding: Partnerships formed through the project are continuing beyond its formal duration, with evidence of independently initiated collaboration and sustained engagement.

There is clear evidence that relationships established through the project are extending into new areas of collaboration. Partners described ongoing joint initiatives, exchange visits, and collaborative efforts that are not directly funded by the project. For example, one participant noted that three partner organizations – SEWA, TGNP, and WISE – are now working together on a new climate-focused initiative, emphasizing that “this is not within the ENGAGE project [...] this is beyond.” Similarly, another example highlights how partnerships have translated

into new project development: organizations “came up with a new project [...] and Coady has no direct role [...] that something came out of ENGAGE, so that’s a great success.” These examples suggest that collaboration is not only continuing but evolving into new forms, driven by shared interest and the strength of partner relationships.

Finding: The continuation of partnerships and collaborative work remains closely tied to access to resources, with uncertainty around how current levels of engagement will be maintained.

While partners expressed commitment to continuing collaboration, many also raised concerns about the feasibility of doing so without project funding. One participant articulated this tension directly: “Right now we have resources [...] we meet quite often [...] all of our time and travel is paid [...] but how are we going to manage [...] without having resources?” This reflects a broader concern that current forms of engagement are resource-intensive and may not be easily sustained. Participants also noted the challenge of maintaining momentum once structured interactions and regular convenings come to an end: “Once the project ends [...] people go on their own way... it’s hard to bring people together.” These accounts highlight a gap between relational commitment and structural sustainability, where willingness to continue collaboration is not matched by clear mechanisms or resources to support it.

Cross-Cutting Factors Supporting Sustainability

Finding: Sustainability was strongest where project approaches were practical, adaptable, and reinforced through ongoing peer and partner relationships.

Across participant, community, and partner organization levels, sustainability appeared strongest where project approaches could be readily integrated into existing roles, routines, and organizational practices. Community-based training participants and partner organization staff consistently emphasized the value of practical tools and methods that could be immediately applied without requiring substantial additional resources, technical specialization, or external support. This practical relevance enabled continued use across livelihood activities, facilitation practices, community engagement, and program implementation.

Adaptability also emerged as an important enabling factor. Partner organizations described modifying tools and approaches to fit local realities, including adapting facilitation methods for low-literacy groups, adjusting livelihood techniques to locally available resources, and integrating participatory approaches into different thematic areas and organizational contexts. This flexibility appears to have supported the continuation of practices beyond the original training environment and contributed to their relevance across diverse settings.

The sustainability of outcomes was also reinforced by strong peer and partner relationships developed through the project. Participants and organizations described continued

exchanges, informal support networks, and independently initiated collaboration that extended beyond formal project activities. In some cases, these relationships were described as sufficiently valuable that organizations expressed willingness to invest their own resources to sustain engagement. Speaking about partner exchange visits, one staff member explained that “now that the relationships exist [...] we would invest in sending our own team [...] the relationships are there.” The relationships and networks formed through ENGAGE created opportunities for ongoing learning, problem-solving, and adaptation, while also supporting the diffusion of knowledge and practices within communities and across partner organizations. Together, the findings suggest that sustainability was strengthened not only by the tools and approaches themselves, but also by the relational networks that reinforced continued learning, adaptation, and exchange over time.

Cross-Cutting Factors Constraining Sustainability

Finding: The sustainability of project results remains shaped by interconnected financial, institutional, and contextual constraints that affect the continuation, scaling, and institutionalization of outcomes.

While there is clear evidence of sustained practices and ongoing collaboration across multiple levels, the findings also indicate that sustainability remains uneven and, in some contexts, fragile. Financial constraints emerged as a recurring challenge, particularly in relation to maintaining partnerships, supporting continued collaboration, and enabling the scaling of training and community-level initiatives. Partner organizations repeatedly emphasized that ongoing engagement would depend on resources for coordination, travel, and implementation. As one staff member reflected, “we need finances [...] that is the reality.”

Broader contextual conditions also shaped the sustainability of project outcomes for participants. In Haiti, for example, one participant described building a poultry enterprise with 300 to 400 chickens, only to lose most of it overnight when gang activity overtook the area. This illustrates how sustainability in fragile settings depends not only on continued financial access and technical skills, but also on broader conditions of physical and economic security. Participants in livelihood activities also described persistent structural barriers related to accessing finance, noting that many women remained unable to secure loans due to lack of collateral or guarantors. As one participant explained, “many people are unable to access these loans because they do not have their own property [...] they cannot find a guarantor.”

Institutional and systems-level constraints also influenced the extent to which project approaches became embedded within partner organizations and sustained over time. Sustainability was generally strongest for practices that were low-cost, practical, and easily integrated into existing routines, while more technically demanding functions, particularly research and knowledge production, demonstrated weaker long-term uptake. In several cases, continued implementation depended heavily on individual initiative, informal

knowledge sharing, or external technical support, with more limited evidence of formalized systems to support continuity and scaling.

This was also evident at the community level, where knowledge transfer remained largely dependent on individual participants rather than embedded community structures. There was little indication of formalized mechanisms, such as organized training cascades, institutional partnerships, or community-led platforms, that would enable consistent and widespread dissemination. As one account noted, “not everyone in the village participated,” and those who did were responsible for sharing knowledge with others. While this contributed to some diffusion of practices, it also meant that sustainability often depended on the motivation, capacity, and availability of specific individuals. Participants also noted that compressed timelines and limited post-training support sometimes reduced opportunities to consolidate learning and strengthen long-term implementation capacity.

Taken together, the findings suggest that sustainability is shaped not by any single factor, but by the interaction between practical relevance, institutional capacity, relational networks, resource availability, and broader contextual conditions. While ENGAGE contributed to sustained changes in practices, relationships, and approaches across multiple levels, the continuation and scaling of these outcomes will likely depend on the extent to which supportive systems, resources, and institutional capacities can continue beyond the life of the project.

7. Recommendations

This section presents actionable recommendations to inform the design and delivery of future initiatives aimed at advancing gender equality and supporting gender-equitable change. Drawing on the evaluation findings, it includes separate recommendations for donors and implementing organizations.

Donors

Support gender equality programming that combines economic empowerment with women’s leadership, collective action, and systems change. The evaluation highlights the value of approaches that combine practical livelihood and leadership support with broader efforts to strengthen women’s leadership, active citizenship, participation, organizing, advocacy, and community engagement. As global development funding priorities increasingly shift toward trade, security, and private sector development, there is a risk that women’s empowerment programming becomes narrowly focused on economic participation alone. Donors should continue supporting integrated approaches that position women not only as economic actors, but also as leaders, organizers, and agents of social change. Sustaining transformative gender equality outcomes requires investment in collective action, political participation, movement-building, and women’s voice and influence alongside economic empowerment activities.

Provide longer-term funding to support gradual and non-linear processes of gender-transformative change. The evaluation suggests that some of the project's most significant contributions, particularly those related to confidence, leadership, participation, active citizenship, and shifts in gendered power relations, emerged gradually over time and remain uneven across contexts. While participants described meaningful changes in self-confidence, community engagement, and decision-making, deeper transformation of gender norms, institutional structures, and social relations appeared to require sustained engagement beyond typical project cycles. Donors should recognize that transformative social change is inherently long-term and non-linear, particularly in contexts shaped by entrenched gender inequalities and structural barriers. Longer-term funding horizons (beyond five years) would provide organizations and communities with greater opportunity to deepen trust, reinforce learning, strengthen collective organizing, and support more sustained shifts in gender norms, institutional practices, and women's influence and active participation within households, communities, and public life. Donors should therefore explore longer-term funding mechanisms that better reflect the time horizons required for transformative social change and address limitations associated with short-term project cycles.

Support flexible and core funding models that strengthen organizational resilience, adaptive capacity, and long-term sustainability. The evaluation highlights the importance of flexible funding arrangements in enabling partner organizations to adapt programming in response to changing and often unpredictable contexts, including COVID-19, political insecurity, economic instability, and shifting community needs. Partners emphasized that the ability to adjust budgets, timelines, and activities helped sustain implementation continuity and responsiveness during periods of disruption. The provision of organizational overhead funding, including a 10% allocation that partners could use without detailed receipt-based reporting, was also identified as an important factor supporting organizational functioning and flexibility. Donors should therefore move beyond narrowly activity-based funding models and expand support for core organizational costs, institutional capacity strengthening, human resources, and adaptive management processes. Flexible and trust-based funding can strengthen organizational resilience, reduce administrative burdens, and enable local organizations to respond more effectively to evolving realities, participant priorities, and changing community contexts.

Recognize organizational strengthening, peer learning, and movement-building as core components of gender equality programming. The evaluation suggests that sustainable progress on women's leadership and gender equality depends not only on project activities, but also on the strength, resilience, and interconnectedness of the organizations and networks advancing this work. Donors should therefore recognize capacity strengthening, peer learning, exchange visits, collaborative research, and cross-partner learning processes as core programmatic investments rather than secondary or optional activities. ENGAGE demonstrated that investments in collective learning and relationship-building supported adaptation, innovation, sustained collaboration, and the uptake of new approaches across contexts. In increasingly constrained and volatile funding environments, strengthening the

broader ecosystem surrounding women's rights organizations is critical for sustaining long-term influence, resilience, active citizenship, and movement-building capacity.

Support MEL systems that better capture qualitative, relational, and emergent dimensions of gender equality and women's empowerment. The evaluation found that many of ENGAGE's most meaningful outcomes, including shifts in women's confidence, agency, bargaining power, solidarity, leadership, and collective action, were qualitative, relational, and non-linear in nature. While highly significant to participants and partners, these changes were not always easily captured through standardized quantitative indicators and donor reporting systems. Partners frequently described tensions between accountability requirements focused on measurable outputs and the realities of transformative social change processes. Donors should therefore support more adaptive, participatory, and context-sensitive MEL systems that combine quantitative and qualitative approaches, create space for emergent outcomes, and recognize storytelling, reflective learning, participatory sensemaking, and locally defined indicators as valid forms of evidence. Strengthening feminist and learning-oriented MEL approaches can help ensure that important but less visible dimensions of empowerment and social transformation are better documented and valued within program and accountability processes.

Implementing Organizations

Continue investing in participatory, asset-based, and locally grounded approaches that strengthen women's collective agency and leadership. The evaluation found that ENGAGE's participatory and ABCD approaches were central to the project's relevance and effectiveness across contexts. Participants consistently valued approaches that recognized and built upon women's existing knowledge, leadership capacities, lived experiences, and community assets, rather than positioning women primarily as beneficiaries or recipients of support. These approaches contributed to increased confidence, solidarity, collective problem-solving, and participation in community and public life. Implementing organizations should therefore continue prioritizing participatory and locally grounded methodologies that create space for dialogue, peer learning, collective reflection, and women-led decision-making. Strengthening women's collective agency and active citizenship requires approaches that position women as active contributors to social change processes rather than passive recipients of project activities.

Prioritize practical, accessible, and adaptable approaches that participants and organizations can sustain within local resource realities. The evaluation suggests that sustainability of project learning outcomes was strongest where tools, approaches, and practices were practical, low-cost, adaptable, and easily integrated into participants' daily lives and organizational routines. Implementing organizations should continue prioritizing facilitation methods, livelihood approaches, and leadership development activities that are accessible across diverse literacy levels, economic realities, and local contexts. Approaches that can be independently maintained, adapted, and applied within existing community and organizational resource constraints are more likely to contribute to sustained

participation and long-term continuity of outcomes, particularly in contexts shaped by economic insecurity, unpaid care responsibilities, or broader social and political instability.

Strengthen structured mechanisms for participant voice, feedback, and co-creation within program design and implementation. The evaluation found that partner organizations demonstrated strong contextual knowledge and responsiveness, particularly through adaptive delivery approaches tailored to participants' realities and needs. However, the identification and prioritization of priorities often remained mediated through organizational structures rather than directly co-defined with participants themselves. Implementing organizations should therefore strengthen structured mechanisms for ongoing participant engagement in program design, adaptation, and reflection processes. This may include participatory planning sessions, iterative consultation cycles, participant advisory groups, community feedback mechanisms, and participatory monitoring approaches that move beyond participation in activities alone. Strengthening women's direct voice and influence within program processes can help deepen ownership, relevance, responsiveness, and active citizenship outcomes over time.

Build stronger community-level systems for knowledge sharing, mentorship, and sustainability. The evaluation found evidence of participants actively sharing learning and practices within their communities; however, this diffusion often depended on informal relationships and individual initiative rather than structured community systems. Implementing organizations should consider developing more formalized mechanisms to support ongoing knowledge transfer and community-level sustainability, such as peer educator models, mentorship structures, training cascades, women-led community platforms, or locally rooted learning groups. More intentional systems for community diffusion can help strengthen continuity, reduce reliance on individual participants, and support broader reach and long-term sustainability of project outcomes.

Invest in peer exchange and collaborative learning as mechanisms for sustainability and adaptation. The evaluation suggests that peer relationships, exchange visits, and collaborative learning processes were important enabling factors for sustainability, adaptation, and ongoing innovation. Implementing organizations should continue creating intentional spaces for cross-context learning, reflection, and exchange among staff, participants, and partner organizations. Beyond supporting technical learning, these processes can strengthen solidarity, deepen collective reflection, reinforce cross-context problem-solving, and support longer-term collaboration across organizations and movements. ENGAGE demonstrates that learning agendas can play an important role not only in knowledge sharing, but also in sustaining relationships, strengthening organizational resilience, and supporting longer-term collaboration across movements and contexts.

Annex 1: Evaluation Matrix

OECD-DAC Criteria	Evaluation question	Indicators	Data sources
Relevance	To what extent were the project's objectives and design aligned with the needs and priorities of implementing organizations and participants, specifically women, and how relevant are the project's approaches and results in the current context?	- Stakeholder perceptions of alignment with needs and priorities - Evidence of contextual adaptation in design or implementation - Continued demand for project approaches or activities	- Review of project and partner documents - KIIs with Coady staff and implementing partners - Participatory SGDs and MSC stories with women participants - Partner reflections during validation session
Effectiveness	To what extent has the project achieved its intended results, and what factors have enhanced or constrained these results, including the contribution of feminist and gender-transformative practices?	- Progress against PMF indicators - Reported changes in women's leadership, agency, and participation - Organizational capacity strengthening outcomes - Examples of gender-transformative practices influencing results	- Review of PMF data and project monitoring reports - KIIs with Coady staff and implementing partners - Participatory SGDs and MSC stories with women participants - Review of notes/recording from MSC session during November MEL meeting - Partner reflections during validation session
Efficiency	To what extent were project activities implemented in a timely and cost-efficient manner, and what lessons can inform improvements in efficiency for similar initiatives?	- Timeliness of activity delivery - Budget utilization patterns - Stakeholder perceptions of efficiency - Identified bottlenecks and adaptive practices	- Review of financial and narrative reports - Review of work plans and implementation timelines - KIIs with Coady staff and implementing partner management staff

OECD-DAC Criteria	Evaluation question	Indicators	Data sources
			• Partner reflections during validation session
Coherence	To what extent did the project complement other gender equity initiatives in the countries of focus, and avoid duplication or overlap?	• Evidence of coordination or collaboration with other initiatives • Stakeholder perceptions of complementarity • Examples of overlap avoided or synergies created • Alignment with national or local gender equality priorities	• KIs with implementing partners • KIs with local partners, networks, and government actors (where feasible) • Review of partner mapping documents and project reports
Impact	To what extent has the project contributed to women's and girls' empowerment and active citizenship in the five target countries, and what lessons can be drawn to improve impact in similar initiatives?	• Self-reported changes in leadership, confidence, collective action, and civic engagement • Examples of women influencing community or organizational processes • Narratives of change linked to ENGAGE activities	• Participatory SGDs with women participants • Review of notes/recording during November MEL meeting • KIs with Coady staff and implementing partners • KIs with local partners and networks • Review of case studies and project learning products • Review of project monitoring data
Sustainability	To what extent are project results likely to be sustained by participants, partners, and communities, and what factors support or constrain their sustainability?	• Evidence of ownership and institutionalization • Continued use of tools, practices, or networks • Partner strategies for post-project continuation • Identified sustainability risks and mitigation strategies	• KIs with Coady staff and implementing partners • Participatory SGDs and MSC stories with women participants • Review of sustainability or exit planning documents • Partner reflections during validation session